

SĀṆKHYA

Comprehensive Philosophical Notes

Based on Chapter 9 of C.D. Sharma's *A Critical Survey of Indian Philosophy*

I. Introduction

Antiquity and Textual Presence

Sāṅkhya is undoubtedly one of the oldest systems of Indian philosophy. References to Sāṅkhya-Yoga doctrines appear in several Upaniṣads — the Chāndogya, the Praśna, the Kaṭha, and particularly the Śvetāśvatara — as well as in the Mahābhārata, in the Gītā, and in the Smṛtis and Purāṇas. Bādarāyaṇa, the author of the Vedānta-sūtra, repeatedly examines whether Sāṅkhya can be regarded as the teaching of the Upaniṣads, and rejects this claim, besides undertaking a rational refutation of Sāṅkhya in the Tarka-pāda.

Śaṅkarācārya regards Sāṅkhya as the 'main opponent' (*pradhāna-malla*) of Vedānta. He concedes that though Sāṅkhya and Yoga are generally accepted by the wise as conducive to the Highest Good, these systems advocate dualism and therefore cannot be supported by the Śruti. On Śaṅkara's reading, terms such as Mahat and Avyakta, which appear to describe Sāṅkhya categories in the Śruti and Smṛti, are in fact used there in the sense of knowledge and action, and of names and forms, respectively — not in their technical Sāṅkhya sense.

Sharma's Historical Inference

Sharma draws an important inference from this defensive posture: the very keenness of Bādarāyaṇa and Śaṅkara to reject the claim that Sāṅkhya — though accepted by the wise — is *not* based on the Upaniṣads because it advocates dualism, suggests that there must have existed thinkers belonging to the Sāṅkhya tradition who did claim it to be the teaching of the Upaniṣads. Though nothing can be said with absolute certainty, Sharma considers it highly probable that Sāṅkhya, in its beginning, was based on the Upaniṣads and had accepted the theistic Absolute; but later, under the influence of Jaina and Buddhist thought, it rejected theistic monism and became content with spiritualistic pluralism and atheistic realism. It is this later, dualistic Sāṅkhya to which Bādarāyaṇa and Śaṅkara are opposed. This hypothesis also explains why some of the later Sāṅkhyas — for example Vijñānabhikṣu in the sixteenth century — tried to revive the earlier theism within Sāṅkhya.

Founder and Textual History

Tradition regards Kapila as the founder of the system. The *Sāṅkhya-pravacana-sūtra*, traditionally attributed to him, is generally regarded by scholars as a work of the fourteenth century CE, for three reasons: (i) it has not been referred to by the earlier writers of the other schools; (ii) it criticizes the rival systems; and (iii) it seeks to revive theism. Sharma maintains that, as far as theism is concerned, the *original* Sāṅkhya was indeed theistic — but the fact that this particular work has been ignored by tradition, while Īśvarakṛṣṇa's Kārikā has been referred to instead by earlier writers, together with the fact that it criticizes other systems even while purporting to be Kapila's own foundational work, tells against its antiquity.

Kapila, Āsuri, and Pañcaśikha — as Īśvarakṛṣṇa himself testifies — seem to have been historical personages whose own works have been lost. Kapila certainly flourished before the Buddha, and he must have composed a Sāṅkhya-sūtra which, unfortunately, is lost. Īśvarakṛṣṇa's *Sāṅkhya-Kārikā* therefore seems to be the earliest available and the most popular work of this system. Besides this we have Gauḍapāda's *Sāṅkhya-Kārikā-bhāṣya*, Vācaspati Miśra's *Tattva-Kaumudī*, and Vijñānabhikṣu's *Sāṅkhya-pravacana-bhāṣya*.

Etymology and Character of the System

The word 'Sāṅkhya' derives from 'saṅkhyā', which carries the sense both of right knowledge and of number. The Gītā uses the word in the sense of knowledge, as does the Mahābhārata elsewhere. Sāṅkhya thus means the philosophy of right knowledge (*samyak khyāti* or *jñāna*). The system is predominantly intellectual and theoretical: right knowledge here is specifically the knowledge of the separation of the Puruṣa from Prakṛti. Yoga, as the counterpart of Sāṅkhya, means action or practice, and shows how the theoretical teachings of Sāṅkhya might be realized in actual practice. Sāṅkhya-Yoga together forms one complete system — the former being the theoretical, the latter the practical aspect of the same teaching.

Sāṅkhya is also the philosophy of numbers, because it deals with twenty-five categories; as a philosophy of numbers, Sharma speculates, it might even have influenced Pythagorean philosophy.

Īśvarakṛṣṇa (fifth century CE) is the representative of classical Sāṅkhya, which had divorced itself from the Upaniṣads under the influence of Jainism and Buddhism — and yet the Vedāntic teaching of absolutism, with which the original Sāṅkhya was associated, asserts itself implicitly even in Īśvarakṛṣṇa. Sharma notes that absolutism is implicit in Jainism, explicit in Mahāyāna Buddhism, and — as will be shown — implicit in Īśvarakṛṣṇa's Sāṅkhya as well.

In summary: Sāṅkhya maintains a clear-cut dualism between Puruṣa and Prakṛti, further maintains the plurality of the Puruṣas, and is silent on God. **It is a pluralistic spiritualism, an atheistic realism, and an uncompromising dualism.**

II. Theory of Causation

The Sāṅkhya theory of causation underlies its entire doctrine of Prakṛti. The basic question in any theory of causation is: **does the effect pre-exist in its material cause?** Those who answer in the negative are called **Asatkāryavādins**; those who answer in the affirmative are called **Satkāryavādins**.

Asatkāryavāda (Ārambhavāda)

According to the Asatkāryavādins, the effect is a new creation, a real beginning; the effect (*kārya*) does not pre-exist (*asat*) in its material cause. Otherwise, it is argued, there would be no sense in saying that the effect is 'produced' or 'caused' at all. If the pot already existed in the clay, and the cloth already existed in the threads, and the curd already existed in the milk, then why should the potter exert himself in producing the pot? Why should not the threads directly serve the purpose of the cloth, and why should not milk simply taste like curd? Moreover, on the pre-existence view, the 'production' of an already-existing effect would amount to its repeated birth — which is nonsensical.

This view — also known as Ārambhavāda, the doctrine that production is a genuinely new beginning — is held, in different forms, by several schools:

School	Specific Doctrine
Materialism (Cārvāka)	Svabhāvavāda — production by inherent spontaneous nature
Hīnayāna Buddhism	Anitya-paramāṇuvāda — theory of momentary atoms
Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika	Kṣaṇabhaṅgavāda / Nitya-paramāṇu-kāraṇavāda — eternal atoms as cause
Some followers of Mīmāṃsā	Nitya-paramāṇu-kāraṇavāda

Satkāryavāda and its Two Sub-Varieties

The Satkāryavādins hold that the effect is not a new creation but only an explicit manifestation of that which was implicitly contained in its material cause. Within Satkāryavāda, a further question arises: is the effect a **real transformation** or an **unreal appearance** of its cause?

- **Pariṇāmavāda** (*pariṇāma* = real modification): the effect is a real transformation of the cause. Held by **Sāṅkhya, Yoga, and Rāmānuja**. Sāṅkhya-Yoga's version is specifically called *Prakṛti-pariṇāma-vāda*; Rāmānuja's version is called *Brahma-pariṇāma-vāda*.
- **Vivartavāda** (*vivarta* = unreal appearance): the effect is merely an unreal appearance of the cause. Held by **Śūnyavāda, Vijñānavāda, and Śaṅkara**, respectively termed *Śūnyatā-vivarta-vāda*, *Vijñāna-vivarta-vāda*, and *Brahma-vivarta-vāda*.

The view of Jainism and of Kumārila (Mīmāṃsā) may be called **Sadasatkāryavāda**, because according to them the effect is both real and unreal before its production — real as identical with the cause, and unreal as a modal change thereof — though ultimately both positions incline towards Pariṇāmavāda.

Sāṅkhya's Own Position: Satkāryavāda

Sāṅkhya believes specifically in Satkāryavāda. All material effects are the modification (*pariṇāma*) of Prakṛti. They pre-exist in the eternal bosom of Prakṛti and simply come out of it at the time of creation, returning to it at the time of dissolution. There is neither new production nor utter destruction. Production means development or manifestation (*āvirbhāva*); destruction means envelopment or dissolution (*tirobhāva*). Production is evolution; destruction is involution.

The Five Arguments for Satkāryavāda

- 1. Asadakaraṇāt** — If the effect does not pre-exist in its cause, it becomes a mere nonentity like the hare's horn or the sky-flower, and can never be produced at all.
- 2. Upādānagrahaṇāt** — The effect is only a manifestation of its material cause, because it is invariably connected with it.
- 3. Sarvasambhavābhāvāt** — Everything cannot be produced out of everything. This suggests that the effect, before its manifestation, is implicit in its material cause.

4. Śaktasya śakyakaraṇāt — Only an efficient cause can produce that for which it is potent. This again means that the effect, before its manifestation, is potentially contained in its material cause; production is only an actualization of the potential. Were it not so, curd should be produced out of water, cloth out of reeds, and oil out of sand-particles.

5. Kāraṇabhāvāt — The effect is the essence of its material cause and, as such, identical with it. When the obstructions in the way of manifestation are removed, the effect naturally flows out of its cause. Cause and effect are the implicit and the explicit stages of the same process: the cloth is contained in the threads, the oil in the oil-seeds, the curd in the milk. The effect pre-exists in its material cause.

*asadakaraṇād upādānagrahaṇāt sarvasambhavābhāvāt · śaktasya śakyakaraṇāt
kāraṇabhāvāc ca satkāryam — Sāṅkhya-Kārikā, 9.*

III. Prakṛti

The theory that causation means a real transformation of the material cause leads directly to the concept of Prakṛti as the root-cause of the world of objects. All worldly effects are latent in this uncaused cause, since infinite regress must be avoided. Prakṛti is the potentiality of nature, ‘the receptacle and nurse of all generation’.

The Six Names of Prakṛti and Their Rationale

As the uncaused root-cause it is called **Prakṛti**; as the first principle of the universe it is called **Pradhāna**; as the unmanifested state of all effects it is known as **Avyakta**; as the extremely subtle and imperceptible thing which is only inferred from its products, it is called **Anumāna**; as the unintelligent and unconscious principle, it is called **Jada**; and as the ever-active unlimited power, it is called **Śakti**.

The products of Prakṛti are caused, dependent, relative, many, and temporary, since they are subject to birth and death, to production and destruction; but Prakṛti itself is uncaused, independent, absolute, one, and eternal, being beyond production and destruction. Its extreme subtlety renders it unmanifest and imperceptible; its existence is inferred solely through its products. Motion is inherent in it in the form of Rajas. As the source of the inanimate world, it is itself unconscious. The entire world of objects is implicit in the bosom of Prakṛti; evolution is the explicit manifestation of this world of objects, while dissolution is the return of this world to Prakṛti.

Why Not Consciousness, and Why Not Atoms, as the Source?

Sāṅkhya believes that consciousness cannot be regarded as the source of the inanimate world, as Vedānta and Mahāyāna believe, because an intelligent principle cannot transform itself into the unintelligent world. On the other hand, the material atoms of the physical elements too cannot be regarded as the cause of this world — as Cārvākas, Nyāya and Vaiśeṣika, Jainism and Hīnayāna Buddhism, and Mīmāṃsā wrongly believe — for two reasons: first, atoms cannot explain the subtle products of matter such as intellect, mind, and ego (which differ from the pure consciousness that belongs to Puruṣa alone, and are here regarded as internal organs); and second, the unity of the universe points to a single cause, whereas atoms are scattered and many. Unintelligent, unmanifest, uncaused, ever-active, imperceptible, eternal, and one — Prakṛti alone is the final source of this world of objects, implicitly and potentially contained in its bosom.

The Five Proofs for the Existence of Prakṛti

1. Bhedānām parimāṇāt — All individual things in the world are limited, dependent, conditional, and finite. The finite cannot be the cause of the universe. Logically, we must proceed from the finite to the infinite, from the limited to the unlimited, from the *peras* to the *apeiros*, from the temporary to the permanent, from the many to the one. It is this infinite, unlimited, eternal, and all-pervading Prakṛti which is the source of the universe.

2. Samanvayāt — All worldly things possess certain common characteristics by which they are capable of producing pleasure, pain, and indifference. Hence there must be a common source composed of the three Guṇas, from which all worldly things arise.

3. Kāryataḥ pravṛtteś ca — All effects arise from the activity of the potent cause. Evolution means the manifestation of the hitherto implicit as the explicit. The activity that generates evolution must be inherent in the world-cause. And this cause is Prakṛti.

4. Kāraṇakāryavibhāgāt — The effect differs from the cause, and hence the limited effect cannot be regarded as its own cause. The effect is the explicit and the cause the implicit state of the same process. The effects therefore point to a world-cause where they are potentially contained.

5. Avibhāgād vaiśvarūpyasya — The unity of the universe points to a single cause. And this cause is Prakṛti.

bhedānām parimāṇāt samanvayāt śaktiḥ pravṛtteś ca · kāraṇakāryavibhāgād avibhāgād vaiśvarūpyasya — Sāṅkhya-Kārikā, 15.

The Three Guṇas

Prakṛti is said to be the unity of the three Guṇas held in equilibrium (*guṇānām sāmāyāvasthā*). The three Guṇas — Sattva, Rajas, and Tamas — are the constituents of Prakṛti and, through it, of worldly objects. Being subtle and imperceptible, their existence is inferred from their effects: pleasure, pain, and indifference respectively.

Although called Guṇas ('qualities'), they are *not* ordinary qualities or attributes in the Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika sense. They themselves possess qualities such as lightness, activity, and heaviness. They are extremely fine and ever-changing elements which *make up* Prakṛti — Prakṛti is nothing apart from them. They are not qualities which Prakṛti-the-substance possesses; rather, they themselves constitute Prakṛti. They are the factors, or constituents, or elements, of Prakṛti. They are called Guṇas for three possible reasons: because they are the elements of Prakṛti, which alone is called substantive; or because they are subservient to the end of the Puruṣa; or because they are intertwined, like three strands, to make up the rope of Prakṛti which binds the Puruṣas.

Guṇa	Literal Meaning	Colour	Principle of	Characteristics & Effects
Sattva	real, existent	white	manifestation / goodness	Light, bright, buoyant (<i>laghu</i>), illuminating (<i>prakāśaka</i>). Luminosity of light, power of reflection, upward movement, pleasure, happiness, contentment, and bliss are all due to it.

Rajas	foulness	red	motion	Restless activity, feverish effort, wild stimulation. Mobile (<i>chala</i>) and stimulating (<i>upaṣṭambhaka</i>). Produces pain.
Tamas	darkness	dark	inertia	Ignorance, sloth, confusion, bewilderment, passivity, negativity. Heavy (<i>guru</i>) and enveloping (<i>varaṇaka</i>), opposed to Sattva and (by arresting activity) to Rajas as well. Produces apathy and indifference.

These three Guṇas are never separate. They are in conflict and yet co-operate with one another, and are always found intermingled — compared to the oil, the wick, and the flame of a lamp, which, though opposed, co-operate to produce light. They are imperceptible and are inferred from their effects. All things are composed of these three Guṇas, and the differences between things are due to the different combinations of the Guṇas. The nature of a thing is determined by the preponderance of a particular Guṇa: things are called good, bad, or indifferent; intelligent, active, or slothful; pure, impure, or neutral, on account of the predominance of sattva, rajas, or tamas respectively. When the Guṇas are held in a state of equilibrium, that state is called Prakṛti; evolution of worldly objects does not take place at this state.

The Guṇas are said to be ever-changing; they cannot remain static even for a moment. Change is said to be of two kinds — homogeneous (*sarūpa-pariṇāma*) and heterogeneous (*virūpa-pariṇāma*). During the state of dissolution (*pralaya*) of the world, the Guṇas change homogeneously — sattva changes into sattva, rajas into rajas, and tamas into tamas. This change does not disturb the equilibrium of the Guṇas, and, unless the equilibrium is disturbed, evolution cannot take place. Evolution starts only when there is a heterogeneous change in the Guṇas and one predominates over the other two, bringing about a terrific commotion in the bosom of Prakṛti.

The Rasalīna Couplet

The nature of the three Guṇas is beautifully brought out, Sharma notes, in a Hindi couplet by the poet Rasalīna. The poet says that the eyes of the beloved are white, red, and dark, and are full of nectar, intoxication, and poison — with the result that, once they pierce the heart of the lover, he experiences the joy of life, the agony of restlessness, and the inertia of death, all together. The recollection of the beloved gives him joy and makes life worth living; separation causes acute pain and makes him restless; the intensity of love makes him forget everything and become inactive, unconscious, and almost dead. Sattva is white and is like nectar, and gives joy; rajas is red and is like intoxication, and gives pain; tamas is dark and is like poison, and produces unconsciousness.

amī-halāhala-mada-bhare śveta-śyāma-ratanāra · jiyata, marata, jhuki jhuki parata, jehi chitavata ika bāra.

Īśvarakṛṣṇa himself echoes this image: ‘We bow to Prakṛti, the red-white-dark, the unborn mother and “nurse and receptacle of all generation”.’ Such, Sharma concludes, is the conception of Prakṛti in Sāṅkhya.

ajām ekām lohita-śukla-kṛṣṇām bahvīḥ prajāḥ sṛjamānām namāmaḥ

IV. Puruṣa

The other of the two co-present, co-eternal realities of Sāṅkhya is the Puruṣa, the principle of pure Consciousness. Puruṣa is the soul, the self, the spirit, the subject, the knower. It is neither body, nor senses, nor brain, nor mind (*manas*), nor ego (*ahaṅkāra*), nor intellect (*buddhi*). It is not a substance which possesses the quality of Consciousness; Consciousness is its essence. It is itself pure and transcendental Consciousness — the ultimate knower, the foundation of all knowledge. It is the pure subject and, as such, can never become an object of knowledge. It is the silent witness, the emancipated alone, the neutral seer, the peaceful eternal. It is beyond time and space, beyond change and activity. It is self-luminous and self-proved. It is uncaused, eternal, and all-pervading. It is the indubitable real, the postulate of knowledge, and all doubts and denials pre-suppose its existence. It is called *nīstraiguṇya* (beyond the three Guṇas), *udāsīna* (indifferent), *akartā* (non-agent), *kevala* (alone), *madhyastha* (neutral), *sākṣī* (witness), *draṣṭā* (seer), *sadāprakāśasvarūpa* (ever-luminous by nature), and *jñāta* (knower).

The Five Proofs for the Existence of Puruṣa

1. Saṅghātaparārthatvāt (teleological proof) — All compound objects exist for the sake of the Puruṣa. The body, the senses, the mind, and the intellect are all means to realize the end of the Puruṣa. The three Guṇas, Prakṛti, the subtle body — all are said to serve the purpose of the self. Evolution is teleological, not purposive by accident; Prakṛti evolves itself in order to serve the Puruṣa's end.

2. Trigūṇādiviparyayāt (logical proof) — All objects are composed of the three Guṇas and therefore logically presuppose the existence of the Puruṣa, who is the witness of these Guṇas and is himself beyond them. The three Guṇas imply the conception of a *nīstraiguṇya* — that which is beyond them.

3. Adhiṣṭhānāt (ontological proof) — There must be a transcendental synthetic unity of pure Consciousness to co-ordinate all experiences. All knowledge necessarily presupposes the existence of the self. The self is the foundation (*adhiṣṭhāna*), the fundamental postulate of all empirical knowledge. All affirmations and all negations equally presuppose it; without it, experience would not become experience.

4. Bhokṛtṛbhāvāt (ethical proof) — Non-intelligent Prakṛti cannot experience its own products. So there must be an intelligent principle to experience the worldly products of Prakṛti. Prakṛti is the enjoyed (*bhogyā*), and so there must be an enjoyer (*bhoktā*). All objects of the world have the characteristic of producing pleasure, pain, and bewilderment — but pleasure, pain, and bewilderment have meaning only when there is a conscious principle to experience them. Hence Puruṣa must exist.

5. Kaivalyārtha pravṛtteḥ (mystical or religious proof) — There are persons who try to attain release from the sufferings of the world. The desire for liberation and emancipation implies the existence of a person who can try for, and obtain, liberation. Aspiration presupposes the aspirant.

*saṅghātaparārthatvāt trigūṇādiviparyayād adhiṣṭhānāt · puruṣo'sti bhokṛtṛbhāvāt
kaivalyārtham pravṛtteś ca — Sāṅkhya-Kārikā, 17.*

The Plurality of the Puruṣas

Unlike Advaita Vedānta, and like Jainism and Mīmāṃsā, Sāṅkhya believes in the plurality of the Puruṣas. Comparable to the Jīvas of the Jains, the souls of Rāmānuja, and the monads of Leibniz, the Sāṅkhya Puruṣas are subject to **qualitative monism and quantitative pluralism**: the selves are all essentially alike, and only numerically are they different. Their essence is consciousness. Bliss, notably, is regarded as *different* from consciousness, and is the product of the sattva-guṇa (i.e. bliss is not intrinsic to the Puruṣa as such).

Three Arguments for the Plurality of Puruṣas

1. The souls have different sensory and motor organs and undergo separate births and deaths. Had there been only one Puruṣa, the birth or death of one should have meant the birth or death of all, and any particular experience of pleasure, pain, or indifference by one should have been equally shared by all. Hence the souls must be many.
2. If the self were one, bondage of one should have meant bondage of all, and liberation of one should have meant liberation of all. The activity of one should have made all persons active, and the sleep of one should have lulled all other persons into sleep.
3. Though the emancipated souls are all alike and differ only in number, being all beyond the three Guṇas, yet the bound souls relatively differ in qualities also, since in some sattva predominates, while in others rajas, and in still others tamas. Hence their difference.

jananamaraṇākaraṇānāṃ pratiniyamād ayugapat pravṛtteś ca · puruṣabahutvaṃ siddhaṃ traiguṇyaviparyayāc caiva — Sāṅkhya-Kārikā, 18.

V. Evolution

Prakṛti is regarded as essentially dynamic. If motion were not inherent in Prakṛti, it could not be given to it by any outside agency; and if motion once ceased in Prakṛti, it could not re-appear. Hence Prakṛti is always changing. Even in dissolution there is homogeneous change (*sarūpa* or *sajātīya pariṇāma*) in Prakṛti, when all three Guṇas are in the state of equilibrium. It is only when heterogeneous change takes place — when rajas vibrates and makes sattva and tamas vibrate — that the equilibrium is disturbed and evolution takes place.

Sattva, the principle of manifestation, and rajas, the principle of activity, were formerly held in check by tamas, the principle of non-manifestation and non-activity. But when rajas, the principle of activity, vibrates and makes the other two vibrate, the process of creation begins. Creation is not the new creation of worldly objects, but only their manifestation — it is only the making explicit of that which was formerly implicit.

Evolution is regarded as cyclic and not linear. There is no continuous progress in one direction, but alternating periods of evolution (*sarga*) and dissolution (*pralaya*) in a cyclic order. Evolution is again said to be teleological and not mechanical or blind: evolution takes place for serving the purpose of the Puruṣa. Prakṛti, the Guṇas, the senses, the mind, the ego, the intellect, the subtle body — all are constantly serving the end of the Puruṣa. This end is either worldly experience (*bhoga*) or liberation (*apavarga*). Puruṣa needs Prakṛti for enjoyment as well as for liberation, for saṃsāra as well as for Kaivalya. Evolution supplies objects to be enjoyed by the Puruṣa, and also works for his liberation by enabling him to discriminate between himself and Prakṛti.

The Unresolved Problem: How Does Contact Occur?

Now the crucial question is: how does evolution actually take place? Evidently, when heterogeneous motion arises and rajas disturbs the equilibrium of the Guṇas. But how, then, is the equilibrium disturbed? Sharma states plainly that Sāṅkhya fails to answer this question satisfactorily.

Sharma diagnoses the fundamental blunder of Sāṅkhya as its separation of Prakṛti and Puruṣa into absolute and independent entities. As a matter of fact, the subject and the object are two aspects of the same reality, which holds them together and yet transcends them. All realistic pluralism, of whatever brand, has failed to answer this question satisfactorily. If Prakṛti and Puruṣa are absolutely separate and independent entities, they can never unite together, nor can there be any *tertium quid* to unite them; and if they cannot unite, evolution cannot take place.

Sāṅkhya's own answer is that the disturbance of the equilibrium of the Guṇas, which starts evolution, is made possible by the 'contact' of Puruṣa and Prakṛti. Puruṣa without Prakṛti is lame, and Prakṛti without Puruṣa is blind — 'theory without practice is empty and practice without theory is blind'; 'concepts without percepts are empty and percepts without concepts are blind.' Prakṛti needs Puruṣa in order to be known, to be seen, to be enjoyed (*darśanārtham*); and Puruṣa needs Prakṛti in order to enjoy (*bhoga*) and also in order to obtain liberation (*apavarga*) — in order to discriminate between himself and Prakṛti and thereby obtain emancipation (*kaivalyārtham*). If Prakṛti and Puruṣa remain separate, there is dissolution; for creation, they must unite. Just as a lame man and a blind man can co-operate — the lame may sit on the shoulders of the blind and point to him the way, while the blind may walk, and thus both can reach the destination, though neither of them could have done that separately — similarly, the inactive Puruṣa and the non-intelligent Prakṛti co-operate to serve the end, and this union disturbs the equilibrium of the Guṇas and leads to evolution.

The Cascading Difficulties

But how can these two opposed and independent entities really come into contact? Sāṅkhya realizes this difficulty, and in order to avoid it says that there is no *real* contact between Puruṣa and Prakṛti — that only the **proximity** of the Puruṣa, the mere fact that Puruṣa is near Prakṛti (*puruṣa-sannidhi-mātra*), is sufficient to disturb the equilibrium of the Guṇas and thus lead to evolution.

But here Sāṅkhya falls into another difficulty. The Puruṣa being always near Prakṛti (for the inactive Puruṣa cannot move), evolution should never stop, and dissolution would become impossible. Evolution, then, would be beginningless, and the very conception of Prakṛti as the state of equilibrium of the three Guṇas would become impossible. Sāṅkhya finds itself caught between two horns of a dilemma: either no contact, and hence no evolution; or else no equilibrium, and hence no Prakṛti and no dissolution.

In order to avoid these difficulties, Sāṅkhya now posits the theory of the **semblance of a contact** (*saṃyogābhāsa*). There is, of course, no real contact (*saṃyoga*) between Puruṣa and Prakṛti; there is only a semblance of a contact, and it is this semblance which leads to evolution. Puruṣa is reflected in the intellect (*buddhi*) and wrongly identifies himself with his own reflection in the buddhi. It is this reflection of the Puruṣa which comes into contact with Prakṛti, and not the Puruṣa himself.

But buddhi, or Mahat, is itself regarded as the *first evolute* of Prakṛti — so how can it arise before evolution, in order to receive the reflection of the Puruṣa? To avoid this difficulty it is said that the Puruṣa is reflected in Prakṛti itself. If so, however, liberation and dissolution

would become impossible, because Prakṛti would always be there, and it would be the essential nature of the Puruṣa to identify himself with his reflection in the Prakṛti — he would never get liberation, and the very purpose for which evolution starts would be defeated. Moreover, the reflection being always there, there would be no dissolution and so no equilibrium of the Guṇas, and hence no Prakṛti (on Sāṅkhya's own definition of it). Again, if a mere semblance of a contact is sufficient to disturb the equilibrium, then evolution itself becomes a mere semblance of evolution — an appearance only (*vivarta*), and no real transformation (*pariṇāma*) of Prakṛti at all — which would contradict Sāṅkhya's own foundational commitment to Satkāryavāda.

“Thus we see that in order to defend the initial blunder of regarding Puruṣa and Prakṛti as absolute and independent entities, Sāṅkhya commits blunders after blunders.”

VI. The Evolutes

Mahat / Buddhi

The first product of evolution is called **Mahat**, ‘the Great’. It is the germ of this vast world of objects, including intellect, ego, and mind. It is cosmic in its nature; but it has a psychological aspect too, in which it is called **Buddhi** or intellect. Buddhi is distinguished from Consciousness: Puruṣa alone is pure consciousness. Buddhi, being an evolute of Prakṛti, is material — made of the finest matter — and is thus capable of reflecting clearly the consciousness of the Puruṣa, like a wireless set capable of receiving aerial waves. On account of the reflection of the Puruṣa in it, buddhi becomes apparently conscious and intelligent. The senses, the mind, and the ego function for buddhi, or intellect, which functions directly for the Puruṣa. Its functions are said to be ascertainment and decision. It arises when sattva predominates; its original attributes are virtue (*dharma*), knowledge (*jñāna*), detachment (*vairāgya*), and power (*aiśvarya*). When it gets vitiated by tamas, these attributes are replaced by their opposites. Memories and recollections are stored in buddhi.

Ahaṅkāra

Mahat produces **Ahaṅkāra**, the principle of individuation. Its function is to generate self-sense (*abhimāna*). It produces the notion of ‘I’ and ‘mine’ — the individual ego-sense. Puruṣa wrongly identifies himself with this ego, and knows himself as the agent of actions, desirer of desires, striver for ends, and possessor and enjoyer of ideas, emotions, volitions, and also of material objects.

Ahaṅkāra is said to be of three kinds:

- 1. Vaikārika** or **Sāttvika**, when sattva predominates — viewed cosmically, it produces manas and the five sensory organs and five motor organs; viewed psychologically, it produces good deeds.
- 2. Bhūtādi** or **Tāmasa**, when tamas predominates — viewed cosmically, it produces the five subtle elements (*tan-mātras*); viewed psychologically, it leads to indifferent acts, idleness, and sloth.
- 3. Taijasa** or **Rājasa**, when rajas predominates — viewed cosmically, it supplies the energy by which the Sāttvika and the Tāmasa produce their respective evolutes; viewed psychologically, it produces evil deeds.

Manas and the Ten External Organs

Manas, or mind, arises from the Sāttvika Ahaṅkāra and is the subtle and central sense-organ; it can come into contact with several sense-organs at the same time. According to the Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika school, by contrast, manas is eternal and atomic, and therefore cannot come into contact with several senses simultaneously. According to Sāṅkhya, manas is neither eternal nor atomic — it is made up of parts, and so it can come into contact with different senses simultaneously. Sāṅkhya assigns to manas the important function of synthesizing sense-data into determinate perceptions, passing them on to the ego, and carrying out the orders of the ego through the motor organs.

The Sāttvika Ahaṅkāra produces, besides manas, the five sensory organs (*jñānendriya*) and the five motor organs (*karmendriya*). The five sensory organs are the functions of sight, smell, taste, touch, and sound. According to the Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika, the five sensory organs are derived from the five gross physical elements; but according to Sāṅkhya, the five senses are functions of the mind and are derived from Ahaṅkāra. The five motor organs (*karmendriya*) are the functions of speech, prehension, movement, excretion, and reproduction.

Buddhi, ahaṅkāra, and manas represent the three psychological aspects of knowing, willing, and feeling — or cognition, conation, and affection respectively. Sāṅkhya calls them material and derives them from Prakṛti. They shine through the light of the Puruṣa and are apparently conscious. All three together are called the internal organs, or *antaḥkaraṇa*, and the vital breaths (*prāṇas*) are said to be their modifications. The five sensory and the five motor organs together are called the ten external organs, or *bāhyakaraṇa*. These are the thirteen *karaṇas*, or organs, of Sāṅkhya.

The Tanmātras and the Gross Elements

From the Tāmasa Ahaṅkāra arise the five subtle essences called **Tanmātras**, or ‘things-in-themselves’ — the essences of sight, smell, taste, touch, and sound. Unlike the Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika ones, they are not derived from the gross elements; rather, the gross elements themselves arise out of these subtle essences. The Tanmātras are neither the qualities nor the differentiae of the gross elements, nor the functions which are the sensory organs, but the subtle essences which produce the gross elements as well as their qualities.

The derivation proceeds cumulatively:

- From the essence of **sound** (*śabda-tanmātra*) arises the element of **ether** (*ākāśa*), together with the quality of sound.
- From the essence of **touch** combined with the essence of sound, arises the element of **air**, together with the qualities of sound and touch.
- From the subtle essence of **colour / sight** combined with those of sound and touch, arises the element of **fire / light**, together with the qualities of sound, touch, and colour.
- From the essence of **taste** combined with those of sound, touch, and colour, arises the element of **water**, together with the qualities of sound, touch, colour, and taste.
- From the essence of **smell** combined with those of sound, touch, colour, and taste, arises the element of **earth**, together with the qualities of sound, touch, colour, taste, and smell.

Evolution is the play of these twenty-four principles which, together with the Puruṣa — who is a mere spectator, outside the play of evolution — constitute the twenty-five categories of Sāṅkhya.

Causal Status of the Twenty-Five Categories

Out of these twenty-five principles: the Puruṣa is neither a cause nor an effect; Prakṛti is only the cause and not the effect; Mahat, Ahaṅkāra, and the five subtle essences are both causes and effects; while the five sensory organs, the five motor organs, the five gross elements, and manas are effects only.

mūlaprakṛtir avikṛtir mahadādyāḥ prakṛtivilāsayāḥ sapta · ṣoḍaśakas tu vikāro na prakṛtir na vikṛtiḥ puruṣaḥ — Sāṅkhya-Kārikā, 3.

The Evolutionary Schema

- 1. Prakṛti** (*cause only*)
 - └ **2. Mahat** / Buddhi (*cause & effect*)
 - └ **3. Ahaṅkāra** (*cause & effect*)
 - └ **4. Manas** (*effect only*)
 - └ **5-9. Five Sensory Organs** (*effect only*)
 - └ **10-14. Five Motor Organs** (*effect only*)
 - └ **15-19. Five Tanmātras** (*cause & effect*)
 - └ **20-24. Five Mahābhūtas** (gross elements) (*effect only*)
- 25. Puruṣa** (*neither cause nor effect — untouched by this evolution*)

The Teleology of Evolution

Evolution is teleological. Everything works to serve the purpose of the Puruṣa, though unconsciously — just as non-intelligent trees grow fruits, or water flows on account of the declivity of the soil, or iron-filings are attracted towards a magnet, or milk flows through the udders of the cow in order to nourish the calf, similarly everything unconsciously tends to serve the purpose of the Puruṣa, whether it is enjoyment or liberation. Prakṛti is the benefactress of Puruṣa. Though Puruṣa is inactive and indifferent and devoid of qualities, yet the virtuous and generous Prakṛti, which is full of qualities, ceaselessly works through various means, in a spirit of detachment, for the realization of the Puruṣa's end, without any benefit to herself. Prakṛti works to liberate the Puruṣa; there is immanent teleology in Prakṛti.

Though Puruṣa is neither a cause nor an effect, yet relatively it is he who should be regarded as the efficient cause as well as the final cause of evolution, though Sāṅkhya formally regards Prakṛti as both the material and the efficient cause. He is like Aristotle's God, the unmoved mover who is beyond evolution. God, the pure intelligence, like the Puruṣa, does not actively participate in evolution. He is the end towards which the creation moves, and the creation moves by his mere presence. The Guṇas, which mutually differ and yet always co-operate, work like the oil, wick, and flame of a lamp, and illuminate the entire purpose of the Puruṣa and present it to the buddhi or the intellect. All the organs work for the realization of the Puruṣa's end and for no other end. The subtle body too works for the sake of the Puruṣa's end. Thus the whole creation unconsciously tends towards the realization of the purpose of the Puruṣa. And creation will continue till all the Puruṣas are liberated. The entire evolution of Prakṛti, therefore, right from the first evolute, the Mahat, up to the last evolutes, the gross elements, is for the purpose of liberating each individual

Puruṣa.

VII. Bondage and Liberation

The Three Kinds of Pain

Earthly life is full of three kinds of pain:

- **Ādhyātmika** — due to intra-organic psychophysical causes, and includes all mental and bodily sufferings.
- **Ādhibhautika** — due to extra-organic natural causes, such as men, beasts, birds, thorns, and the like.
- **Ādhidaivika** — due to supernatural causes, such as the planets, elemental agencies, ghosts, demons, and the like.

Wherever there are Guṇas, there are pains; even the so-called pleasures lead to pain; even the life in heaven is subject to the Guṇas. The end of man is to get rid of these three kinds of pain and suffering. Liberation means complete cessation of all sufferings, which is the *summum bonum*, the highest end of life (*Apavarga* or *Puruṣārtha*).

The Nature of Bondage and the Path to Liberation

Puruṣa is free and pure consciousness. It is inactive, indifferent, and possesses no attributes. Really speaking, it is above time and space, merit and demerit, bondage and liberation. It is only when it mistakes its reflection in the buddhi for itself, and identifies itself wrongly with the internal organ — the intellect, the ego, and the mind — that it is said to be bound. It is the ego, and not the Puruṣa, which is bound. When the Puruṣa realizes its own pure nature, it gets liberated, which in fact it always was. Hence bondage is due to ignorance, or non-discrimination between the self and the not-self, and liberation is due to right knowledge, or discrimination between the self and the not-self.

Liberation cannot be obtained by means of actions. Karma, good or bad or indifferent, is the function of the Guṇas and leads to bondage and not to liberation. Good actions may lead to heaven and bad actions to hell, but heaven and hell alike, like this worldly life, are subject to pain. It is only knowledge which leads to liberation, because bondage is due to ignorance, and ignorance can be removed only by knowledge. The Jīva has to realize itself as the pure Puruṣa through discrimination between Puruṣa and Prakṛti. Actions and fruits, merits and demerits, pleasure and pain, all belong to the not-self. The knowledge that 'I am not (the not-self)', that 'nothing is mine', that 'ego is unreal', when constantly meditated upon, becomes pure, incontrovertible, and absolute, and leads to liberation.

Jīvanmukti and Videhamukti

Sāṅkhya admits both Jīvanmukti and Videhamukti. The moment right knowledge dawns, the person becomes liberated here and now, even though he may be embodied due to *prārabdha* karma. On account of the momentum of past deeds, the body continues to exist for some time, just as the wheel of a potter goes on revolving for some time due to previous momentum, even though the potter has withdrawn his hand from it. As the liberated saint, though embodied, feels no association with the body, no new karma gets accumulated, as all karma loses its causal energy. The final and absolute emancipation — the complete disembodied isolation — automatically results after death.

Sāṅkhya liberation is a state of complete isolation, freedom from all pain, a return of the Puruṣa to its pure nature as consciousness. There is **no pleasure or happiness or bliss** here, for pleasure presupposes pain and is relative to it. Pleasure is the result of sattva-guṇa, and liberation transcends all Guṇas.

The Purely Phenomenal Character of Bondage and Liberation

Sāṅkhya believes that bondage and liberation alike are only phenomenal. The bondage of the Puruṣa is a fiction; it is only the ego, the product of Prakṛti, which is bound, and consequently it is only the ego which is liberated. Puruṣa, in its complete isolation, is untouched by bondage and liberation. If Puruṣa were really bound, it could not have obtained liberation even after a hundred births, for real bondage can never be destroyed. It is Prakṛti which is bound, and Prakṛti which is liberated. Īśvarakṛṣṇa frankly says: Puruṣa, therefore, is really neither bound nor is it liberated, nor does it transmigrate; bondage, liberation, and transmigration belong to Prakṛti in its manifold forms. Prakṛti binds itself with its seven forms.

“There is nothing finer and subtler than Prakṛti; she is so shy that she never reappears before that Puruṣa who has once ‘seen’ her in her true colours. Just as a dancing girl retires from the stage after entertaining the audience, similarly Prakṛti also retires after exhibiting herself to the Puruṣa.”

VIII. God

The original Sāṅkhya, per Sharma’s historical thesis, was monistic and theistic. But the classical Sāṅkhya, perhaps under the influence of Materialism, Jainism, and early Buddhism, became atheistic. It is nonetheless **orthodox**, because it believes in the authority of the Veda. It does not positively establish the non-existence of God; it only shows that Prakṛti and Puruṣas are sufficient to explain this universe, and therefore there is no reason for postulating the hypothesis of God. But some commentators have tried to repudiate the existence of God outright, while the later Sāṅkhya writers, such as Vijñānabhikṣu, have tried to revive the necessity of admitting God.

Those who repudiate the existence of God give the following arguments:

1. If God is affected by selfish motives, He is not free; if He is free, He will not create this world of pain and misery. Either God is unjust and cruel, or He is not free and all-powerful.
2. If He is determined by the law of Karma, He is not free; if not, He is a tyrant.
3. Again, God being pure knowledge, this material world cannot spring from Him: the effects are implicitly contained in their cause, and the material world, which is subject to change, requires an unintelligent and ever-changing cause, and not a spiritual and immutable God.
4. Again, the eternal existence of the Puruṣas is inconsistent with God. If they are the parts of God, they must have some divine power; if they are created by God, they are subject to destruction. Hence there is no God.

IX. General Estimate

The Fundamental Blunder

The logic of the Sāṅkhya system, like that of Jainism, impels it to embrace idealistic monism or absolutism, but it clings, like Jainism, to spiritualistic pluralism and dualistic realism. The fundamental blunder of Sāṅkhya is to treat Prakṛti and Puruṣa as absolutely separate and independent realities. The Prakṛti and Puruṣa of Sāṅkhya thus become mere abstractions, torn away from the context of concrete experience. The object and the subject are relative and not independent and absolute. Experience always unfolds them together. Like the two sides of the same coin, they are the two aspects of the same reality. To dig a chasm between them is to undermine them both — and that is precisely what Sāṅkhya has done.

The logic of Sāṅkhya requires it to maintain the ultimate reality of the transcendental Puruṣa alone, and to regard Prakṛti as its inseparable power. When this Puruṣa is reflected in its own power, Prakṛti, it becomes the empirical ego, the Jīva, the phenomenal. Plurality belongs to this Jīva, not to the transcendental Puruṣa. The subject and the object, the Jīva and the Prakṛti, are the two aspects of the Puruṣa which is their transcendental background. It is the Puruṣa which sustains the empirical dualism between Prakṛti and Jīva, and which finally transcends it. Every Jīva is the potential Puruṣa, and liberation consists in the actualization of this potentiality. This, Sharma argues, is the philosophy to which Sāṅkhya logic points, and which is throughout implicit in Sāṅkhya, but which is explicitly rejected by Sāṅkhya — with the inevitable and unfortunate result that Sāṅkhya has reduced itself to a bundle of contradictions.

The Contact Problem Revisited

If Prakṛti and Puruṣa are absolute and independent, they can never come into contact, and hence there can be no evolution at all. As Śaṅkara has pointed out, Prakṛti being unintelligent and Puruṣa being indifferent, and there being no third principle, no *tertium quid*, there can be no connection of the two. Neither real contact (*saṃyoga*) nor semblance of contact (*saṃyogābhāsa*) nor mere presence (*sānnidhya-mātra*), as we have noticed above, can explain evolution. Sāṅkhya realizes the mistake, but in order to defend the initial blunder, it commits blunders after blunders.

Prakṛti as a Mere Abstraction

The Sāṅkhya account of Prakṛti makes it a mere abstraction, an emptiness of pure object. The original state of Prakṛti is not a harmony, but only a tension of the three Guṇas. The Guṇas point to a state beyond them which gives them harmony and transcends them; Prakṛti does not do that. Hence it is not real; reality is the Puruṣa alone. Again, Prakṛti is unconscious and unintelligent. How can it then explain the teleology which is immanent in creation? If Prakṛti is unconscious and blind, evolution must be mechanical and blind, and there can be no freedom of the will. And if Prakṛti and all its evolutes, from Mahat to the Mahābhūtas, tend to serve the purpose of the Puruṣa, it can be neither unconscious nor independent. Again, if Prakṛti is blind and non-intelligent, it cannot evolve this world, which is full of harmony, order, and purpose. Stones, bricks, and mortar cannot account for the design of a building; mere clay cannot fashion itself into a pot. How, then, can Prakṛti explain the original impetus, the first push, the *élan vital*, which disturbs the equilibrium of the Guṇas?

The argument that Prakṛti works unconsciously for the emancipation of the Puruṣa, just as unintelligent milk flows for the nourishment of the calf, is untenable, because milk flows as there is a living cow, and there is the motherly love in the cow for the calf. Nor can the

modification of Prakṛti be compared to that of grass which turns into milk. Grass becomes milk only when it is eaten by a milch cow, and not when it lies uneaten or is eaten by a bull. The simile of the blind and the lame is also misleading, since the blind and the lame are both intelligent and active beings who can devise plans to realize a common purpose, while Prakṛti is unconscious and Puruṣa is indifferent, and there is no common purpose. The simile of the magnet and the iron is also misleading, because the proximity of the Puruṣa being permanent, there would be no dissolution and hence no liberation, and the very state of Prakṛti as the equilibrium of the Guṇas would be impossible, since the presence of the Puruṣa would never permit the state of equilibrium.

Moreover, activity is said to belong to Prakṛti and enjoyment to Puruṣa. This overthrows the moral law of Karma and brings in the charge of vicarious liability. Poor Puruṣa suffers for no fault of its own. Prakṛti performs actions, and Puruṣa has to reap their fruits, good or bad. And Prakṛti, Sharma observes with some irony, knows how to make delicious dishes, but not to enjoy them.

The Hidden Relativity of the ‘Absolute’ Prakṛti

Though Prakṛti is called absolute and independent, yet there is a note of relativism in the conception of Prakṛti. As a triad of the Guṇas, it points towards the *nīstraiguṇya* Puruṣa as the transcendental reality. At every step it shows its dependence on Puruṣa. It cannot evolve this world by itself without being influenced by the Puruṣa — whether that influence is due to real contact or semblance of contact or mere presence. How can Prakṛti be absolute, then? An absolute Prakṛti is a contradiction-in-terms. If it is absolute, why should it care to serve the purpose of the Puruṣa? Does this not make it subservient to the Puruṣa? And if it is unconscious and blind, how can it serve this purpose at all?

Though Sāṅkhya calls Prakṛti impersonal, its descriptions of Prakṛti are full of personal notes: Prakṛti is called a dancing girl; she is feminine; she is virtuous and generous; she is the benefactress of the Puruṣa; she serves the Puruṣa’s purpose in a spirit of perfect detachment for no gain to herself; and yet she is blind; she is extremely delicate and shy and cannot stand the eye of the Puruṣa; she is seven-rainbow-coloured and wants to attract the Puruṣa. How can such a Prakṛti be absolute and impersonal? Puruṣa is untouched by bondage, liberation, and transmigration. It is Prakṛti who binds herself and liberates herself and transmigrates. Prakṛti is said to vanish for that Puruṣa who has ‘seen’ her, though she continues to exist for others. Does this not make Prakṛti relative? If she ‘vanishes’, how can she be absolute and eternal? Why not frankly equate Prakṛti with Avidyā? Either maintain a plurality of Prakṛtis, or equate it with Avidyā. These descriptions of Prakṛti, Sharma concludes, clearly show that Vedānta is *implicit* in Sāṅkhya.

The Confusion of Puruṣa with the Empirical Jīva

Sāṅkhya throughout makes a confusion between the Puruṣa, the transcendental subject, and the Jīva, the empirical ego, which is the product of the reflection of Puruṣa in Buddhi or Mahat. Sāṅkhya rightly emphasizes that the Puruṣa is pure consciousness, that it is the foundation of all knowledge, and that it is beyond bondage, liberation, and transmigration. Puruṣa has really nothing to do with the play of Prakṛti; it is a mere spectator, and is not among the *dramatis personae*. It is not contaminated by action; it is self-proved and self-shining; it is the transcendental subject which appears as the phenomenal ego. We cannot derive consciousness from Prakṛti or matter, nor can we regard consciousness as a quality. The self is not a substance, but a subject. It is the Alone, the unseen seer, the

transcendental Absolute.

But Sāṅkhya soon forgets its own position and reduces the ultimate Puruṣa to the level of the phenomenal ego. Some of the proofs advanced in support of the existence of Puruṣa are proofs only for the phenomenal ego. Puruṣa is called enjoyer and Prakṛti enjoyed — but if Puruṣa is the transcendental subject, how can it be an enjoyer? If it is passive, indifferent, and inactive, how can it enjoy? Again, how can the transcendental reality be split into many reals? How can there be a plurality of the transcendental subjects, the Puruṣas?

The Plurality of Puruṣas Undermined

Of course, no one denies the plurality of the empirical egos, the Jīvas. But the manyness of the egos, the empirical souls, does not lead us to the manyness of the transcendental selves, the Puruṣas. In fact, all the arguments advanced by Sāṅkhya to prove the plurality of the Puruṣas turn out to be arguments to prove the plurality of the Jīvas — which none has ever denied. Sāṅkhya proves the plurality of the Puruṣas by such flimsy arguments as: if there were only one Puruṣa, the birth or death or liberation or experience of pleasure or pain or indifference of one should lead to the same result in the case of all — forgetting its own doctrine that the Puruṣa is not subject to birth or death or bondage or liberation or any action. Realizing this grave defect, commentators like Vācaspati, Gauḍapāda, and Viśṇūabhikṣu have maintained the reality of one Puruṣa only.

If Sāṅkhya can reduce all objects to one Prakṛti, why can it not reduce all the empirical souls to one Puruṣa by the same logic? And why can Prakṛti and the empirical Puruṣa not be reduced to the Absolute Puruṣa by the same logic? Again, if all the Puruṣas are essentially similar, if the essence of all is pure consciousness, how can they be really many? Differences and distinctions constitute individuality. If all the Puruṣas are essentially the same, there is no meaning in proclaiming their quantitative plurality. **Numerical pluralism is sheer nonsense.**

The Negativity of Kaivalya

Another grave defect in Sāṅkhya is in its conception of liberation. Liberation is regarded as a negative cessation of the three kinds of pain, and not as a state of positive bliss. Sāṅkhya feels that bliss is a product of sattva-guṇa and cannot remain in liberation, which is the state beyond the Guṇas. But Sāṅkhya forgets that the bliss in liberation is not empirical happiness produced by sattva. This bliss is also transcendental in character. It is beyond both pain and pleasure. What is related to pain is empirical pleasure and not transcendental bliss. The negative Kaivalya suggests an influence of the Hīnayāna Nirvāṇa. Will the liberated Puruṣas, the eternally isolated units, not represent 'a vast array of sad personalities'? If liberation is an annihilation (*nāsmi, nāham*) of human personality and not its perfection, the ideal of liberation is most uninspiring. It must be substituted by an ideal of positively blissful eternal existence in the bosom of the Absolute.

Sharma's Prescriptive Conclusion

Sāṅkhya, therefore, should let its Prakṛti glide into Avidyā, the inseparable power of the Puruṣa; its Prakṛti-pariṇāma-vāda into Puruṣa-vivarta-vāda; its so-called empirical Puruṣa into the phenomenal Jīva; its negative Kaivalya into positively blissful Mokṣa; and should, instead of maintaining the plurality of Puruṣas and creating an unbridgeable chasm between the subject and the object, recognize the Absolute Puruṣa, the transcendental subject which gives life and meaning to the empirical subject and object and holds them

together and ultimately transcends them both.

End of Notes · Source: C.D. Sharma, A Critical Survey of Indian Philosophy, Chapter Nine: "Sāṅkhya", pp. 149-168.